

Flying mammals



Flying squirrel

The glider

The flying squirrel has loose pieces of skin on either side of its body. When it jumps, it opens them out like an umbrella and can glide for 100 m (330 ft), steering with its tail and legs.

Some mammals have “wings”, so they can glide through the air, but bats are the only mammals that can actually fly by flapping their wings.

Bats

Bats' wings are actually long arms with skin stretching between each finger. Their thumbs stick out like small claws to grip branches.

Greater mouse-eared bats

During the day, bats roost in dark caves, trees, or under a roof of a building. They sleep upside-down.

Bats squeak to find one another in the dark.

Claw-like thumb

Vampire bat

The saliva of vampire bats numbs the skin of its victims so they can't feel the blood-sucking bite.

The real vampire

The vampire bat's favourite meal is fresh blood, even yours! It feeds by digging its sharp teeth into the flesh, then laps up the blood.

Bat features

A bat's head shape reflects the way it feeds.



Fruit bat: has a long snout, and a long tongue to sip nectar and eat fruit.



Long-eared bat: this bat has large ears that can hear insects' wings flapping.



Long-nosed bat: these bats have long noses to help them smell flowers.